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Sales management control systems: review, synthesis, and directions for future exploration

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Sales management control systems (SMCSs) are designed to align salespeople's activities and actions with organizational objectives. This article reviews and synthesizes over 50 SMCS articles published in sales, marketing, and management journals over the past 30 years. We begin by building a comprehensive framework that enables us to classify prior research into digestible categories (e.g., SMCSs as antecedents, SMCSs as consequences). Next, we present an analysis of gaps in the literature. Among other findings, our analysis reveals that there is an overwhelming focus on the use of formal (specifically behavior- and outcome-based) controls as compared to their informal control counterparts. Finally, we suggest avenues for future research: (1) mapping and understanding the full spectrum of control mechanisms, (2) developing a fuller understanding of the often-overlooked forms of control (e.g., input and cultural controls), and (3) more thoroughly analyzing how controls operate (or do not operate) as an integrated system.

Keywords: sales management control systems; sales-force controls; formal controls; informal controls

Sales management control systems (SMCSs) are frequently implemented by firms to align salespeople with organizational objectives (Anderson and Oliver 1987; Darmon and Martin 2011; Jaworski 1988). For example, organizations often use outcome-based SMCSs such as sales quotas as a way of defining, monitoring, and evaluating the performance of salespeople (Anderson and Oliver 1987; Jaworski 1988). While managers design SMCSs to align salespeople with organizational objectives, the literature has noted that controls may originate from other internal stakeholders, such as peers who attempt to align salespeople with group norms (Jaworski 1988; Ouchi 1979). As such, controls have been defined as "attempts by management or other stakeholders within the organization to influence the behavior and activities of marketing personnel to achieve desired outcomes" (Jaworski 1988, 24).

The purpose of this review essay is to take stock of the body of work on SMCSs between 1987 and 2016. Specifically, we focus on three research objectives. First, we aim to build a model that parsimoniously captures the full scope of research in the area. Our "antecedents, controls, and consequences" framework enables us to categorize the majority of SMCS research, including important mediator and moderator variables. Second, given this framework, we will additionally identify key "research gaps" in the literature. For example, our review of the SMCS literature, to date, reveals that research, including recent reviews of the SMCS literature (e.g., Baldauf, Cravens, and Piercy 2005; Darmon and Martin 2011), has focused on opportunities related largely to the examination of formal managerial controls. Informal forms of control (e.g., peer control) in organizations (e.g., Ouchi 1979) and marketing (e.g., Jaworski and MacInnis 1989) remain underrepresented. Third, we will provide an agenda for future research.

To achieve these objectives, we have divided this article into five sections. We begin with a section on the definitions of key SMCS terms. Next, we review our methodology for the selection of articles to review. Third, we review the roots of controls in the field of marketing. We term this section "Early beginnings." Given the definitions and roots, we turn to our organizing framework, which guides the main body of this article. Our fifth and final section examines future research. Here, we shift our attention to the major gaps in the literature.

Definitions and key terms

Control theory has a rich history. Seminal works widely acknowledge that controls take both formal and informal forms (Dalton 1971; Hopwood 1974; Merchant 1985; Ouchi 1979; Thomas 1983). *Formal controls* are written policies and procedures, initiated by management, to align salespeople with stated marketing objectives (Anderson and Oliver 1987; Jaworski 1988). Depending on the

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timing of management initiation, formal controls are divided into three types (Jaworski 1988): (1) *Input controls*, for example, are leveraged before the start of a sales activity (e.g., sales leads); (2) *behavioral controls*, contrastingly, are imposed throughout the activity (e.g., sales scripts); and (3) *output controls* are based on actual performance after the activity (e.g., sales to quota).[1]

Informal controls, on the other hand, are unwritten and typically worker-initiated forms of control that operate in the social environment of the sales organization (e.g., values, norms, objectives; Jaworski 1988). Depending on who is initiating the control, informal controls are divided into three types (Jaworski 1988; Jaworski and MacInnis 1989): (1) *Self-controls*, the personal setting and management of work-related objectives, (2) *social/peer/ professional controls*, the work-group–level values, norms, and objectives with collective monitoring and feedback, and (3) *cultural controls*, the broad organization-level values and norms that exert influence over individual decisions and actions.

Sampling of SMCS research (1987–2016)

We followed a four-stage process known as the SALSA process (search, appraise, synthesize, analyze), outlined by Grant and Booth (2009), in preparing this review article. First, we conducted our search with EBSCOhost, ABI/INFORM Global, and Google Scholar search engines, using the key terms *sales management control systems, sales force control systems, formal controls, informal controls*, and included partial terms like *sales, sales force, control systems*, and *controls*. Given our primary interest in *sales* control systems, our investigation focused on publications from prominent sales, marketing, and management journals between 1987 (when this topic emerged in marketing) and 2016.

Eighty-three articles were appraised for inclusion in the review. Conceptual SMCS articles, including other review articles, are included in this review (seven total). Empirical articles are only in our review if the studies included a sales-specific sample (49 total articles including one meta-analysis), with four notable exceptions made for highly influential control articles from top journals that have a marketing sample not specific to sales (e.g., Jaworski, Stathakopoulos, and Krishnan 1993). In total, 27 of the articles appraised failed to meet this criterion (e.g., Fortado 1994) and, as a result, were not included in the review. The Web Appendix (Table A1) provides a tabulation of the 56 articles thus reviewed.

Approximately 30% of the reviewed articles come from the *Journal of Personal Selling & Sales Management*, while nearly 15% are from the *Journal of Marketing*. The *Journal of Marketing Research*, the *Journal of Business Research*, and *Industrial Marketing Management* each account for almost 9% of articles in the review. A little over 7% of the reviewed articles come from the *Journal of the Academy of Marketing Science*. Additional academic journals each represent less than 2% of reviewed articles. For a complete tabulation of represented journals, including the number of articles in the review and the percentage of total articles from each journal, please refer to Web Appendix (Table A2).

To synthesize 30 years of SMCS literature, we drew on an overarching framework/approach adopted by Zachary et al. (2015) by identifying and organizing around themes and levels of analyses in the body of work. Our initial examination suggested that the SMCS literature could best be analyzed by organizing the extant work around three key themes: (1) SMCSs as consequences of the internal and external environment; (2) SMCSs as antecedents of both salesperson-level and sales-force/sales organization–level outcomes (including contingencies that influence these relationships); and (3) SMCSs as moderators. Next, we structured our review, developing the manuscript according to this framework (presented in Figure 1). This helped us analyze the literature, highlight the gaps in our current knowledge, and identify opportunities for future research.

Early beginnings and basic SMCSs conceptualizations

SMCS literature is usually traced back to the seminal works of Anderson and Oliver (1987) and Jaworski (1988). The theoretical underpinnings of their conceptualizations of sales/marketing personnel controls are similar (Baldauf, Cravens, and Piercy 2005). However, the two conceptualizations have key differences in their treatment of formal and informal controls as well as how they measure control.

Early conceptual frameworks

Drawing upon economics theories, like agency theory, Anderson and Oliver (1987) presented two types of formal controls (behavioral and outcome) as primary mechanisms employed by sales managers to address the problem of how to control agents (i.e., salespeople) to whom they had delegated decision-making authority (Eisenhardt 1985). Behavioral controls are characterized as having higher levels of supervision—directing, monitoring, evaluating, and rewarding of salespeople (i.e., controls dimensions)—than outcome controls (Baldauf, Cravens, and Piercy 2005). Anderson and Oliver (1987) did not explicitly include informal controls in their SMCS framework. However, they acknowledged a third type of control system called "clan" control (from organization theory), whereby sales managers control salespeople through socialization. However, clan control was only considered as a system of last resort in sales situations where both behavioral and outcome (i.e., performance) information is

unavailable to sales managers (Anderson and Oliver 1987).

Meanwhile, drawing upon the cybernetic roots of management control theories (e.g., Dalton 1971; Hopwood 1974; Merchant 1985), Jaworski (1988) identified three types of formal controls used among marketing personnel: input, process, and output. Process controls are conceptually equivalent to Anderson and Oliver's (1987) behavioral controls. Output controls and outcome controls are also the same concept. Input controls, on the other hand, are distinct mechanisms leveraged by managers before the start of a sales activity (e.g., resources) to align salespeople with organizational goals (Jaworski 1988). Subsequent work by Challagalla and Shervani (1996) extended work on formal controls by disaggregating process controls into two types: activity controls (i.e., managerial control over salespeople's day-to-day activities) and capability controls (i.e., managerial control over salespeople's skills and abilities). They also identified three conceptually distinct dimensions of process and output controls: information (i.e., goal-setting, monitoring, and feedback), rewards, and punishments (Challagalla and Shervani 1996, 1997; Dalton 1971).

In contrast to Anderson and Oliver (1987), who broadly referred to informal controls as "clan" control, Jaworski (1988) also identified three distinct types of informal controls that are likely to be influential in shaping and directing salesperson actions: self, social/peer/professional, and cultural/organization-wide (Ouchi 1979). In later work, Jaworski and colleagues typified four different "control systems" that account for the use of multiple controls operating simultaneously: high control (high formal control, high informal control), bureaucratic control (high formal control, low informal control), clan control (low formal control, high informal control), and low control (low formal control, low informal control; Jaworski, Stathakopoulos, and Krishnan 1993).

Measurement

Anderson and Oliver (1987) considered behavioral controls to be high levels of formal control and output/outcome controls to be low levels of formal control. Oliver and Anderson (1994) further proposed that behavioral and outcome controls be measured as opposite ends of a single continuum on a semantic differential scale. On the other hand, Jaworski (1988) considered behavioral/process controls and output/outcome controls as having equal potential to be perceived as controlling. Jaworski and MacInnis (1989) thus proposed process and output controls as two independent constructs, to be measured as two separate/independent dimensions on reflective scales (based on Jaworski's 1988 conceptualization).

Subsequent empirical work on sales controls suggests that salespeople can experience high (or low) levels of behavioral/process and output/outcome controls simultaneously (Challagalla and Shervani 1997; Cravens et al. 2004; Jaworski, Stathakopoulos, and Krishnan 1993; Samaraweera and Gelb 2015). These subsequent conceptual and empirical works support the argument that these constructs are independent and therefore need to be conceptualized and measured along separate dimensions.

Summary

Albeit in different ways, SMCS conceptualizations from Anderson and Oliver (1987) and Jaworski (1988)—and subsequent studies—have recognized the existence of two broad categories of controls (formal and informal; i.e., clan). They also considered the strength of controls, and explored different dimensions of controls (e.g., evaluating, monitoring, rewarding, etc.). In this review article, we divide extant control types into two broad categories and six distinct types: three formal controls (input, behavioral, output), and three informal controls (self, social, and cultural). Table 1 elaborates on these different types of controls and their underlying dimensions.

SMCSs as antecedents

In this three-part section, we present a framework (see Figure 1) of the SMCS literature (Web Appendix, Table A1) around the broad themes of SMCSs as antecedents, SMCSs as consequences, and SMCSs as moderators. We begin by examining SMCSs as antecedents to different outcomes.

Researchers have varyingly suggested that important salesperson-level consequences of controls include cognitions, perceptions, capabilities, affects, attitudes, motivations, behaviors, and performance (Anderson and Oliver 1987; Jaworski 1988). Jaworski (1988) emphasized that salesperson outcomes would depend on the fit between control use and the sales environment. Stathakopoulos (1996) later stressed a need for greater understanding of how controls influence salesperson–customer relationships. Select researchers have also recommended that control consequences be evaluated at the sales-force/sales organization level (e.g., Cravens et al. 1993; Piercy, Cravens, and Morgan 1999). Control systems are designed and implemented by sales managers at this level of analysis, and situational factors like territory design are both determinants of SMCSs and potential moderators of the relationship between SMCSs and sales organization effectiveness (Babakus et al. 1996).

We discuss SMCSs as antecedents to different categories of outcomes at the salesperson and sales-force/organization levels as outlined in the "SMCS outcomes" box in Figure 1. Ninety-two percent of examined empirical studies report findings on the antecedent role of SMCSs. At each level of analysis, we will further examine the

Table 1. Sales control types and dimensions.

Sales control types	Disaggregated dimensions
Formal Controls: Written, management-initiated means used to align salespeople with organizational objectives (Dalton 1971; Hopwood 1974; Merchant 1985; Thomas 1983). Divided into three forms based on the timing of management intervention (Jaworski 1988)	
Input controls: Actions taken by the sales organization prior to a sales activity, such as recruiting, training, or resource allocation (Jaworski 1988)	
Behavioral/process controls: Management defines how salespeople should work and tries to gain their compliance (Anderson and Oliver 1987) The sales organization attempts to influence the methods that salespeople use to achieve results, such as following a process or procedure (Jaworski 1988)	
Activity controls: Management control over the day-to-day activities of salespeople (Challagalla and Shervani 1996, 1997; Jaworski and MacInnis 1989) Capability controls: Management control over the skills and abilities of salespeople (Challagalla and Shervani 1996, 1997)	Information: The content of controls (i.e., goal setting, monitoring, feedback; Challagalla and Shervani 1996, 1997; Dalton 1971; Merchant 1985) Rewards: The use of controls as positive reinforcement (Challagalla and Shervani 1996, 1997; Dalton 1971; Jaworski and Kohli 1991) Punishments: The use of controls as negative reinforcement (Challagalla and Shervani 1996, 1997; Dalton 1971; Jaworski and Kohli 1991)
Output/outcome controls: Salespeople are held accountable for their results (Anderson and Oliver 1987) Sales results are evaluated against prespecified criteria, such as a sales quota (Jaworski, 1988)	Information: The content of controls (i.e., goal setting, monitoring, feedback; Challagalla and Shervani 1996, 1997; Dalton 1971; Merchant 1985) Rewards: The use of controls as positive reinforcement (Challagalla and Shervani 1996, 1997; Dalton 1971; Jaworski and Kohli 1991) Punishments: The use of controls as negative reinforcement (Challagalla and Shervani 1996, 1997; Dalton 1971; Jaworski and Kohli 1991)
Informal controls: Unwritten, worker-initiated mechanisms that influence salespeople, but may or may not align them with organizational objectives (Dalton 1971; Hopwood 1974, Merchant 1985; Thomas 1983). Divided into three forms based on who is doing the controlling (Jaworski 1988) "Clan" controls are control through socialization (Anderson and Oliver 1987; Ouchi 1979)	
Self-controls: Salespeople set personal objectives, self-monitor progress, and course correct as needed (Dalton 1971; Hopwood 1974; Jaworski 1988; Merchant 1985; Thomas 1983)	
Social/peer/professional controls: The sales team establishes norms, monitors the conformity of members, and acts when deviances occur (Dalton 1971; Jaworski 1988)	
Cultural controls: Broad organization-wide values and norms that guide the decisions and actions of salespeople (Jaworski 1988)	

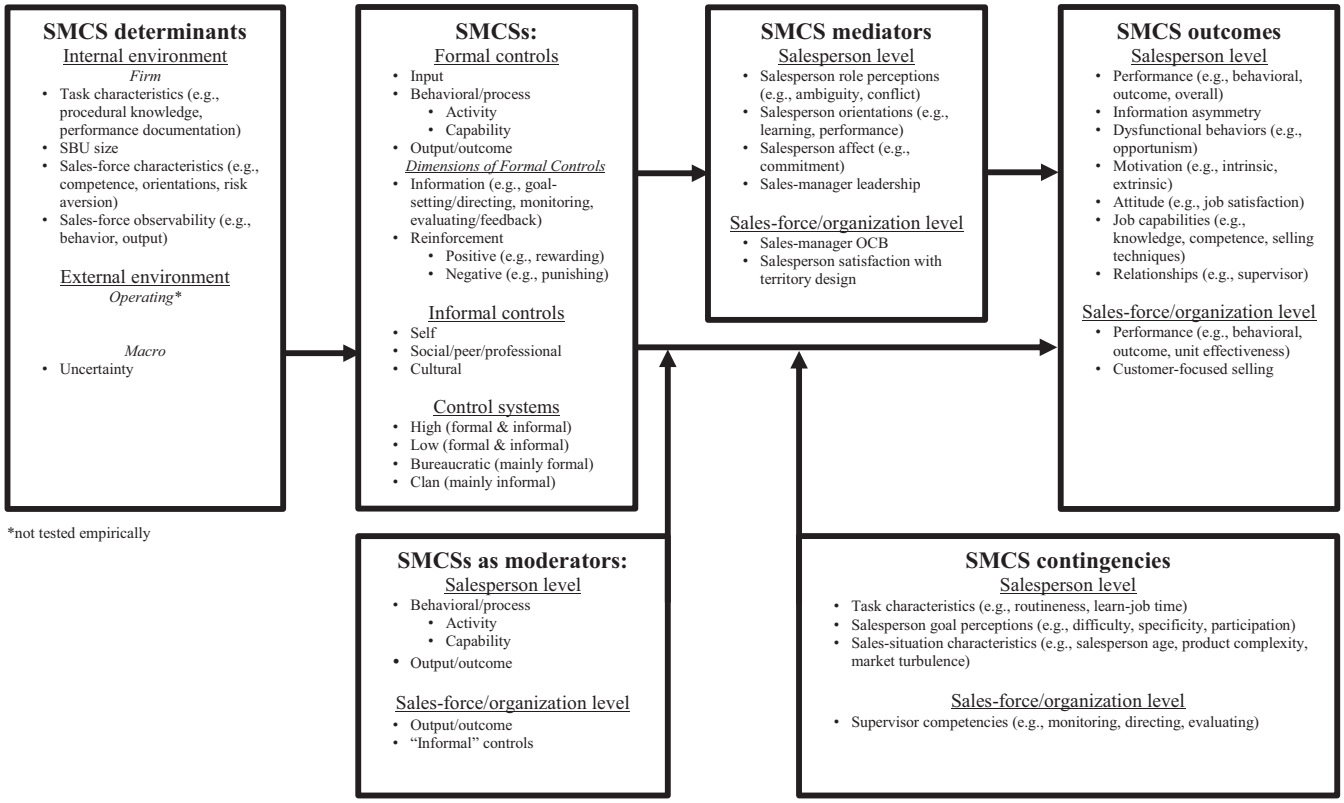

Figure 1. Thirty years of SMCS research.

mediators (Figure 1, "SMCS mediators" box) and moderators (Figure 1, "SMCS contingencies" box) of these relationships.

Salesperson-level outcomes

Empirical SMCS studies have primarily focused on the direct effect of controls on salesperson-level outcomes, namely, salesperson performance, behavior, and attitudes, among others. In fact, 67% of reviewed empirical articles evidence the effect of SMCSs on outcomes at this level of analysis.

Performance

In the SMCS literature, salesperson performance is differentiated as behavioral performance (i.e., behaviors applied by salespeople to meet job criteria; Anderson and Oliver 1987), outcome performance (i.e., sales results attributed to the salesperson; Churchill, Ford, and Walker 1979), or overall performance (i.e., a combination of behavioral and outcome performance measures; see Behrman and Perreault 1982).

Most studies we researched have investigated the effect of controls on behavioral performance at the sales-force/organization level of analysis (e.g., Baldauf, Cravens, and Piercy 2001b; Piercy, Cravens, and Morgan 1999). However, research conducted by Piercy et al. (2006) suggests that behavioral controls play an important antecedent role in a salesperson's organizational citizenship behaviors (OCBs; i.e., individual, discretionary actions taken by salespeople who promote goodwill within their organizations; Podsakoff and MacKenzie 1994). Further, researchers have reported a positive relationship between output controls and outcome performance among marketing managers as well as salespeople (Evans et al. 2007; Jaworski, Stathakopoulos, and Krishnan 1993). On the other hand, sometimes behavioral controls have been found to be negatively associated with salesperson outcome performance (e.g., ability to achieve percentage of quota targets; Onyemah and Anderson 2009). However, a recent meta-analysis on the effects of behavioral- and outcome-based controls showed that, overall, both types of controls have a positive relationship with salesperson outcome performance (e.g., exceeding sales targets; Samaraweera and Gelb 2015). Then there is Cravens et al. (2004), who looked at how different control systems impact salesperson overall performance (e.g., ability to make sales presentations and ability to achieve sales results), finding high-control systems (i.e., formal and informal controls) to have the strongest relationship with salesperson overall performance.

In summary, limited results suggest the importance of fit between the type of controls in use and the type of performance being measured. Although findings suggest that the efficacy of both behavioral and output controls is enhanced when combined with informal controls, specific relationships between informal controls and salesperson performance (of all types) are largely unknown. We suggest that future research involve investigating which formal and informal controls complement and could also perhaps substitute for one another in determining salesperson performance.

Information asymmetry

Transaction cost analysis suggests that SMCSs should be managed to avoid information asymmetry because subordinates and supervisors must maintain the same level of knowledge to prevent information from being used opportunistically by one party (Williamson 1981). A primary purpose of controls is to exchange information, thus reducing the potential for such asymmetries. Behavioral, output, and social controls have all been found to reduce information asymmetry (Agarwal 1996; Jaworski and MacInnis 1989; Ramaswami 2002). However, it would be interesting to know more about situations when the use of multiple different types of controls causes information asymmetry due to cognitive overload (e.g., a salesperson is unable to process all control information) or goal conflict (e.g., a salesperson withholds information from the manager due to loyalty to another party).

Dysfunctional behaviors

Certain dysfunctional behaviors can arise when salespeople feel pressure to meet criteria (Jaworski and MacInnis 1989), including gaming (i.e., behaviors are technically in line with controls but hurt the organization in the long run), smoothing (i.e., results are presented in a way that makes them appear consistent over time), focusing (i.e., information is presented in a selective manner so it will be perceived more positively), and inaccurate reporting (i.e., results are purposefully misreported). These four forms of dysfunctional behavior (taken together) are also referred to as opportunism in SMCS literature.

Some researchers have found both behavioral and output controls to have a positive relationship with opportunism (Ramaswami 1996, 2002). On the other hand, some researchers have reported that output controls are more likely to lead to dysfunctional behaviors (i.e., recommending decisions that violate societal norms; Robertson and Anderson 1993). Additional findings suggest that it is important to disaggregate behavioral controls as either activity or capability and look at their specific dimensions (i.e., information, rewards, and punishments). For example, a salesperson perceiving activity information (e.g., information from supervisor about sales activity expectations) is more likely to engage in opportunism than a salesperson perceiving output information (e.g., information from supervisor about market share targets) or capability information (e.g., guidance from supervisor on improving selling skills; Choi, Dixon, and Jung 2004). Jaworski and MacInnis (1989) showed that, among marketing personnel, self-controls have a negative relationship with opportunism, while social controls have no effect.

Overall, results indicate that different dimensions of behavioral and output controls (e.g., information, rewards, punishments) may have different relationships with a salesperson's dysfunctional behaviors. Preliminary findings suggest that self-controls reduce dysfunctional behaviors. We suggest that future research consider investigating how input controls (e.g., sales support) provided prior to a sales activity might reduce opportunistic behavior. In addition, it would be interesting to know whether cultural controls (e.g., organizational norms) have a negative relationship with behaviors like gaming.

Motivation

There are two general types of motivation: extrinsic motivation comes from the anticipation of rewards and/or punishments, and intrinsic motivation is rooted in the spontaneous enjoyment of an interesting activity that promotes personal growth (Gagne and Deci 2005). Motivation is one of the strongest determinants of salesperson overall performance (Churchill et al. 1985). Oliver and Anderson (1987, 1994, 1995), for example, reported finding that behavioral controls are related to greater intrinsic motivation among salespeople; output controls are related to greater extrinsic motivation. However, a third "hybrid" system with moderate levels of controls (i.e., directing, monitoring, rewarding) was found to have the strongest positive relationship with intrinsic motivation (Oliver and Anderson 1995).

Limited research suggests that dimensions of controls (i.e., information, rewards, and punishments) and strength of controls are likely to play an important role in maintaining a salesperson's intrinsic motivation for the job. Further, a mismatch between controls and incentives is likely to be detrimental to a salesperson's intrinsic motivation. Research to date, however, has not explored the relationships between motivation and either input controls or informal controls. For example, to what degree can informal controls substitute for or complement behavioral controls in promoting intrinsic motivation?

Attitude

Some SMCS studies have looked at relationships between controls and salesperson attitude, namely, job satisfaction—that is, the degree to which a salesperson finds characteristics of the sales job and work environment to be rewarding (Churchill, Ford, and Walker 1974).

Behavioral controls have been found to be more positively associated (than outcome controls) with a salesperson's job satisfaction, acceptance of managerial authority, cooperation as part of a team, and positive attitudes about performance appraisals (Oliver and Anderson 1994, 1995). Whether controls are behavioral or output, their information (i.e., setting, monitoring, and evaluating of objectives) and rewards (i.e., positive reinforcements) dimensions have been shown to have a positive relationship with a salesperson's satisfaction with his or her supervisor (Challagalla and Shervani 1996; Jaworski and Kohli 1991), and with salesperson attitudes about organizational change (Sarin, Challagalla, and Kohli 2012). Punishment dimensions (i.e., negative reinforcements) of behavioral controls, on the other hand, were found to lower salesperson satisfaction with the supervisor (Challagalla and Shervani 1996). Finally, high-control systems have been found to have a stronger relationship with a salesperson's job satisfaction than other control combinations (i.e., bureaucratic, clan, low; Cravens et al. 2004).

Overall, behavioral controls have a positive relationship with favorable salesperson attitudes. However, the valence of feedback and reinforcement measures (i.e., positive or negative), strength of information, combinations of formal/informal controls, and perceptions of leadership all influence this relationship. Additional research is needed to determine what specific combinations of formal controls (including input controls) and informal controls are most likely to enhance salesperson job satisfaction and under what conditions.

Job capabilities

Behavioral controls have been shown to have a stronger association with desirable salesperson job capabilities (e.g., product knowledge, professional competence, attention to agency goals, and sales expertise) than output controls (Anderson and Oliver 1987; Oliver and Anderson 1994, 1995; Rouzies and Macquin 2002). In the absence of pressure to meet certain short-term outcomes, salespeople are more likely to develop long-term goals, strategies, and relationships. Important research questions about how input controls (e.g., training) affect capabilities, particularly in conjunction with other controls, remain to be explored.

Relationships

Given the critical importance of relationships in selling—particularly with emphasis on adaptive selling (Spiro and Weitz 1990), customer orientation (Kohli and Jaworski 1990), relationship marketing (Morgan and Hunt 1994), and the value of customer-facing relationships (Kumar, Sunder, and Leone 2014)—SMCS research on this topic is sparse. Atuahene-Gima and Li (2006) examined how both output and behavioral controls shape the relationships between inexperienced salespeople and their supervisors. They found that both control types have the potential to enhance supervisee trust depending on several circumstances (e.g., training intensity, market volatility, supervisor orientation; Atuahene-Gima and Li 2006).

Limited research suggests that it may be important to consider the sales situation, market conditions, and length of time that a relationship has had to develop. Future research should consider how different control types affect sales relationships. Of interest would be whether control use should evolve over time as a supervisor develops a relationship with a salesperson.

Salesperson-level mediators

Inconclusive results indicate the potential importance of mediating variables in the relationship between SMCSs and salesperson-level outcomes. Empirical articles that provide evidence of mediation account for 10% of investigated SMCS articles.

Salesperson role perceptions

A salesperson's role perceptions (i.e., understanding of job expectations; Walker, Churchill, and Ford 1977) can be positive or negative. Positive role perceptions, like role clarity (i.e., level of certainty about job expectations), have been found to enhance performance (Jaworski and Kohli 1991). Negative role perceptions include role ambiguity (i.e., level of uncertainty about job expectations), role stress/job tension (i.e., level of discomfort with work expectations; Jaworski 1988; Jaworski and MacInnis 1989; Lusch and Jaworski 1991), and person-role conflict (i.e., level of conflict between personal role orientation and salesperson role expectations; Jaworski, Stathakopoulos, and Krishnan 1993). Negative role perceptions have been found to reduce performance (Challagalla and Shervani 1996; Lusch and Jaworski 1991).

Behavioral and output information (including positive and negative feedback) were found to enhance role clarity/reduce role ambiguity among salespeople, thus enhancing performance (Challagalla and Shervani 1996; Jaworski and Kohli 1991; Ramaswami 2002). On the other hand, in some cases, behavioral controls have been found to increase both job tension and person-role conflict, subsequently reducing performance (Challagalla and Shervani 1996; Jaworski, Stathakopoulos, and Krishnan 1993). Cultural controls have also been found to reduce role ambiguity and person-role conflict among marketing executives (Jaworski, Stathakopoulos, and Krishnan 1993). Additional findings suggest that social controls reduce not only role ambiguity (Jaworski, Stathakopoulos, and Krishnan 1993) but role stress (Lusch and Jaworski

1991) and job tension (Agarwal 1996) among various marketing personnel. Research also suggests that self-controls reduce role stress among retail store managers (Lusch and Jaworski 1991). Jaworski and colleagues (1993) further found high-control systems associated with lower role ambiguity among marketing executives relative to bureaucratic, clan, or low-control systems. This relationship was later substantiated among salespeople (Craven et al. 2004).

Research to date suggests that a salesperson's role stress/job tension is related to both high levels of control over salesperson activities and high accountability without adequate guidance. According to empirical attention to the relationships among controls and role perceptions, a balance between the use of formal and informal controls helps reduce role tension, stress, and conflict. Future research should investigate whether informal controls help reduce any negative effects that behavioral controls have on performance through negative role perceptions.

Salesperson orientations

There is significant interest in the SMCS literature in the relationship between controls and a salesperson's orientations. Generally, this research has focused on two orientations: learning and performance. Learning orientation denotes a salesperson's desire to continuously improve selling techniques and capabilities regardless of achievement. Alternatively, a performance orientation denotes a salesperson's desire to achieve results and extrinsic rewards (Kohli, Shervani, and Challagalla 1998).

Research indicates that output controls and capability controls each have a positive relationship with a salesperson's learning orientation (Kohli, Shervani, and Challagalla 1998). By contrast, output controls and activity controls are positively related to performance orientation (Kohli, Shervani, and Challagalla 1998). Results also show that performance orientation has a positive relationship with a salesperson's outcome performance (e.g., generating sales), while learning orientation does not (Kohli, Shervani, and Challagalla 1998). Performance orientation has also been shown to moderate the effects of SMCSs on salesperson-level attitudes. Sarin, Challagalla, and Kohli (2012) found that output- and behavioral-risk containment (i.e., supervisor mitigates risk of controls) each have a greater positive influence on salespeople's attitudes about organizational change when the salesperson has a strong performance orientation (Sarin, Challagalla, and Kohli 2012). However, the effects of output and behavioral rewards do not vary across salespeople's performance-orientation levels (Sarin, Challagalla, and Kohli 2012). Finally, research has shown that behavioral controls have a positive relationship with salespeople's perceptions of their organization's customer orientation (i.e., focus on quality and customer satisfaction); however, these perceptions were not found to influence salespeople's job satisfaction or overall performance (Evans et al. 2007).

A salesperson's orientations seem to be partly reflective of those of their supervisor's. For example, when the focus is on improving sales capabilities, salespeople are more oriented toward learning. Results suggest that a salesperson's performance orientation may only be relevant to the relationships between some dimensions of formal controls (e.g., risk containment) and certain sales outcomes (e.g., attitudes). Interestingly, a supervisory focus on output controls is related to both a salesperson's learning orientation and performance orientation. Perhaps most surprisingly, current knowledge suggests that a salesperson's perception of the firm's customer orientation is not related to job satisfaction or performance. It would be interesting to know more about the role of cultural controls in the relationship between a firm's customer orientation and a salesperson's job satisfaction. Also, what role do salesperson-customer relationships play?

Salesperson affect

Researchers interested in the impact of SMCSs on salesperson affect (i.e., experience of feeling or emotion) have primarily investigated organizational commitment—that is, the degree to which an individual identifies and becomes involved with an organization (Kelman 1958; Mowday, Steers, and Porter 1979).

Behavioral controls (Oliver and Anderson 1994, 1995) and high-control systems (Cravens et al. 2004) have been found to have a strong positive relationship with a salesperson's organizational commitment. Affective commitment (i.e., a salesperson's identification with the organization) has further been shown to mediate the positive relationship between a high-control system (e.g., behavioral, output, and social) and a salesperson's customer orientation and overall performance (Joshi and Randall 2001). Behavioral controls have similarly been found to positively affect a salesperson's vigor (i.e., level of positive energy, willingness to expend effort), dedication (i.e., level of involvement, commitment, enthusiasm, and pride), and absorption (i.e., engagement with the work), with all relationships being enhanced by supervisory support (Khan and Saeed 2015).

Mixed results suggest that behavioral controls play an important antecedent role to a salesperson's organizational commitment. SMCSs that comprise informal controls appear to be influential as well. Although Joshi and Randall (2001) found evidence that affective commitment mediates the relationship between SMCSs and performance, it is important to note that other studies examining the link between organizational commitment and salesperson performance have found this relationship to be insignificant (e.g., Sager and Johnston 1989). Clearly, additional work is needed in this area.

Sales-manager leadership

A handful of SMCS studies have investigated the mediating role that sales-manager leadership plays between controls and optimal salesperson-level outcomes. Evans et al. (2007), for example, found capability controls to have a positive relationship with salesperson job satisfaction through perceptions of sales supportiveness (i.e., the degree to which salespeople perceive concern for their well-being and appreciation for their contributions; Shore and Tetrick 1991), and perceptions of sales innovativeness (i.e., the degree to which a salesperson perceives that the organization is flexible and willing to incorporate new ways of thinking: Hellriegel and Slocum 1974). Similarly, Panagopoulos and Dimitriadis (2009) reported finding behavioral controls to be positively related to organizational commitment and salesperson job satisfaction, through transformational leadership (i.e., leadership that guides change by creating a vision; e.g., Podsakoff et al. 1990).

Empirical evidence implies that behavioral controls could be more effective when they are implemented by exceptional sales managers (e.g., Evans et al. 2007). However, we currently lack knowledge on the intermediary role of sales manager leadership between different types of controls (i.e., output, input, self, social, and cultural) and key salesperson-level outcomes.

Salesperson-level contingencies

A few researchers have recognized that there are important factors present in the sales environment (e.g., task characteristics, salesperson perceptions) that have the potential to influence the relationship between SMCSs and salesperson-level outcomes. Studies that reveal contingencies affecting this relationship represent 14% of articles included in the review.

Task characteristics

SMCSs as consequences of the internal environment are an important topic among researchers. However, select studies have also investigated how aspects of the internal environment (i.e., task characteristics) moderate the relationship between SMCSs and salesperson-level outcomes. Task characteristics (e.g., performance documentation, procedural knowledge) refer to the specifications of a position within an organization (Ouchi 1979).

In general, research findings suggest that output controls lead to negative outcomes when explicit pressure to perform (e.g., performance documentation) is high; such pressure leads to dysfunctional behaviors and job tension (Agarwal 1996). Similarly, findings indicate that behavioral controls should be accompanied by high levels of procedural knowledge (i.e., the degree to which managers specify the activities required to achieve certain outcomes; Jaworski 1988) because a lack of understanding about how to achieve results may lead to dysfunctional behaviors (Agarwal 1996). Others have reported finding that the positive relationships between both behavioral and output controls and opportunism attenuate as procedural knowledge increases (Ramaswami 1996, 2002). Additional results suggest that self-controls reduce dysfunctional behaviors only when performance documentation is low and when procedural knowledge is high (Agarwal 1996). On the other hand, results show a negative relationship between social controls and dysfunctional behaviors, job tension, and information asymmetry—regardless of performance documentation or procedural knowledge (Agarwal 1996).

Findings suggests that, if task characteristics cannot be controlled, the use of social controls might help reduce the negative effects of other controls. We suggest that future research should also examine how different task characteristics moderate the relationship between input controls and opportunism.

Salesperson goal perceptions

To help explain inconsistent effects of formal controls on salesperson performance, Fang, Evans, and Zou (2005) investigated three different perceptions of supervisory goal-setting (Locke and Latham 1990): goal difficulty (i.e., how attainable the goal is), goal specificity (i.e., how clearly the goal is defined), and goal participation (i.e., how involved the salesperson is in the goal-setting process) among salespeople in the United States and China.

Overall, results indicate that output controls are positively related to outcome performance when output goals are moderately difficult, although for U.S. salespeople, output goals must also be specific whereas for Chinese salespeople, goals must have low specificity (Fang, Evans, and Zou 2005). Results further suggest that salespeople from both countries generally prefer activity and capability goals with low difficulty and low specificity as these behavioral controls positively influence behavioral performance under such conditions (Fang, Evans, and Zou 2005). In China, high goal participation is also important in determining the positive relationship between behavioral controls and behavioral performance (Fang, Evans, and Zou 2005). This study, among others (e.g., Fang, Evans, and Landry 2005), provides evidence that cultural differences play an important role in control use. However, little is known at this point about how salesperson perceptions of goal characteristics influence the relationships between informal controls (i.e., values, norms, and objectives) and salesperson performance.

Sales-situation characteristics

Flaherty, Arnold, and Hunt (2007) attempted to clarify the effects of different types of controls (i.e., output, behavioral,

social, and self-controls) on salesperson performance by organizing salespeople into clusters according to their "sales situation." A sales situation was observed by clustering salespeople by individual (e.g., age), firm-level (e.g., product complexity), and macro-level (e.g., market turbulence) variables into groups: (1) "sink-or-swim"—transactional, (2) "tried-and-true"—relationship building, and (3) "fixed-but-stable"—account management.

For salespeople in the sink-or-swim cluster, findings suggest that output and behavioral controls each have a positive influence on managers' ratings of salesperson overall performance (Flaherty, Arnold, and Hunt 2007). Similarly, among salespeople in the tried-and-true cluster, behavioral, self, and social controls were each found to also have a positive influence on overall performance (Flaherty, Arnold, and Hunt 2007). However, none of the controls were reported to have influenced overall performance in the fixed-but-stable cluster (Flaherty, Arnold, and Hunt 2007). Along similar lines, while there was no reported difference in the way male and female salespeople perceived controls use, salespeople on teams led by female managers reported greater use of behavioral controls; this led to higher organizational commitment and job satisfaction, but lower performance (Piercy, Cravens, and Lane 2001).

Although it is difficult to draw many definitive conclusions, results lend support to the original assumption that the fit between control system and sales environment is critical when assessing the impact of controls on salespeople (Anderson and Oliver 1987; Jaworski 1988). This study does, however, raise research questions about how sales managers can design SMCSs in ways that are both equitable and effective for all salespeople.

Sales-force/organization–level outcomes

Some studies have investigated how SMCSs influence key outcomes (e.g., performance) at the sales-force/organization level of analysis. All empirical findings detailed in this aggregate outcome category constitute 24% of reviewed articles.

Performance

Research has demonstrated that behavioral controls have a positive relationship with a sales force's behavioral performance and outcome performance (Cravens et al. 1993; Panagopoulos, Johnson, and Mothersbaugh 2015; Piercy, Cravens, and Morgan 1999; Piercy, Low, and Cravens 2004). Further, behavioral controls were found to lead to organizational effectiveness (i.e., organization-level sales volume and growth, profitability, and customer satisfaction) directly (Baldauf, Cravens, and Piercy 2001a; Cravens et al. 1993; Piercy, Low, and Cravens 2004) and through outcome but not behavioral performance (Piercy, Cravens, and Morgan 1999). A meta-analysis on the effects of SMCSs determined that behavioral controls and output controls each have a positive relationship with revenue attainment; for behavioral controls, this relationship was found to be stronger at the organizational level than at the individual level (Samaraweera and Gelb 2015).

In addition, recent research has investigated the influence of informal controls at the sales-organization level. Results suggest that self-, social, and cultural controls each have a positive relationship with behavioral performance; social controls and self-controls positively influenced customer relationship performance as well (Panagopoulos, Johnson, and Mothersbaugh 2015). Consequently, both behavioral performance and customer relationship performance had a positive relationship with outcome performance, which had a positive influence on a firm's financial performance (Panagopoulos, Johnson, and Mothersbaugh 2015).

Overall, empirical evidence suggests that behavioral controls have a positive influence on multiple types of performance at the sales-force/organization level (i.e., behavioral, outcome), which eventually results in positive financial performance. Further, output controls lead to revenue attainment, but perhaps without the development of certain behaviors. Finally, there is compelling evidence that informal controls play an important role in the performance of a sales organization. As with salesperson-level performance, the most compelling future research questions are related to how different control types can be combined to most effectively influence sales-force/organization–level performance.

Customer-focused selling

Researchers have found that behavioral controls and social controls each positively influence adaptive selling (i.e., a sales force's ability to adjust selling techniques to individual customers; e.g., Spiro and Weitz 1990; Guenzi, Baldauf, and Panagopoulos 2014). Output and cultural controls each positively influence both customer-oriented selling (i.e., a sales force's ability to align customer purchase decisions with customer needs; e.g., Kohli and Jaworski 1990) and sales organization effectiveness (Guenzi, Baldauf, and Panagopoulos 2014). Further, customer-oriented selling has a positive relationship with sales organization effectiveness through adaptive selling (Guenzi, Baldauf, and Panagopoulos 2014).

In summary, all four types of formal/informal controls examined in this study led to sales organization effectiveness, albeit through two different selling philosophies. This line of research could be extended by investigating the customer contexts where each selling philosophy (among others) is most effective.

Sales-force/organization-level mediators

Only two examined SMCS empirical studies (4%) offered evidence of mediation between SMCSs and sales-force/

organization–level outcomes. Although these studies have taken an important first step in uncovering the mechanisms that facilitate SMCSs among a sales force, more work is needed in this area.

Sales-manager OCB

Sales manager organizational citizenship behavior (OCB)—i.e., individual, discretionary behavior that is not formally recognized but still supports effective organizational functioning (Organ 1988)—was found to fully mediate the positive relationship between behavioral controls and sales unit overall performance (Piercy, Cravens, and Lane 2012). These results are in line with the mediating role that sales manager leadership variables play between SMCSs and important salesperson-level outcomes, as mentioned previously. We also suggest that additional research may help uncover whether a sales manager's OCB mediates the relationship between different control types and sales unit performance.

Salesperson satisfaction with territory design

Babakus et al. (1996) showed that behavioral controls are positively related to sales organization effectiveness. This effect is mediated through behavioral and outcome performance of the sales force, as well as sales-force satisfaction with the territory design (Babakus et al. 1996). This introduces the question, of what other sales-force–level characteristics mediate this relationship.

Sales-force/organization-level contingencies

Only 2% of reviewed empirical SMCS articles (one study) have examined contingencies of the relationship between SMCSs and sales-force/organization–level outcomes.

Supervisor competencies

As sales manager control competencies (i.e., ability to monitor, direct, evaluate, and reward compared to company peers) increase, the positive relationship between behavioral controls and sales-force performance is strengthened (Piercy, Cravens, and Lane 2012). Results, though not surprising, reinforce the important role that sales managers play in the effective delivery of controls. It would be of great interest to SMCS researchers to better understand what supervisor competencies are relevant to the effective design and implementation of SMCSs.

Summary

Research on the antecedent role of SMCSs primarily provides insights on the effects of behavioral controls and output controls on a wide range of salesperson-level outcomes, with some work on how factors in the internal environment (i.e., task, salesperson, and sales manager characteristics) influence these relationships. Knowledge about the antecedent role of different types of controls, namely, input, self, social, and cultural, is limited at both levels of analysis (i.e., salesperson level and sales-force/organization level).

SMCSs as consequences

Drawing on agency theory, organization theory, transaction cost analysis, and cognitive evaluation theory, Anderson and Oliver (1987) and Jaworski (1988) identified key determinants of SMCSs. These were divided into two broad categories: the internal environment (of the firm), and the external environment. Anderson and Oliver (1987) further specified the internal environment as comprising the characteristics both of the firm and of the sales force. Jaworski (1988) identified the external environment as including both the operating environment (i.e., network of company stakeholders) and the macro environment (i.e., national and global conditions). We summarize studies that investigate SMCSs as consequences of either the firm's internal environment or the broader external environment as depicted in the "SMCS determinants" box in Figure 1. Studies that evidence SMCSs as consequences represent 12% of empirical articles in the review.

Internal environment

The internal environment includes all the elements within a firm's authority (Jaworski 1988). Extant studies that investigate the role the internal environment plays in SMCSs look at characteristics of the sales task or of the sales force. Ten percent of empirical SMCS studies in the review have demonstrated controls as consequences of the internal environment.

Task characteristics

Organization theory suggests that task characteristics should be assessed prior to making any determinations about SMCSs (Ouchi 1979; Ouchi and Maguire 1975; Stathakopoulos 1996). This is critical because the behaviors required for successful performance must be clearly understood by sales managers to know what type of controls are most relevant.

Taken together, empirical SMCS studies on task characteristics as antecedents of control use have yielded several conclusions. When sales tasks require high levels of procedural knowledge, managers tend to rely on behavioral controls (Jaworski and MacInnis 1989; Ramaswami 2002). Greater use of performance documentation is associated with the use of behavioral, output, social, and self-controls (Jaworski and MacInnis 1989; Ramaswami 2002; also see Jaworski 1988 and Ouchi 1979). Sales tasks that have a longer learn-

job time (i.e., time required to learn a task) are related to the use of both output and cultural controls (Jaworski, Stathakopoulos, and Krishnan 1993). Research further suggests that the completeness of an evaluation system (i.e., ability of the evaluation system to capture task complexity) leads to managerial reliance on behavioral, output, social, and cultural controls (Jaworski, Stathakopoulos, and Krishnan 1993). Finally, routineness (i.e., tractability and measurability of a task) has demonstrated a negative relationship with the use of output, social, and cultural controls (Jaworski, Stathakopoulos, and Krishnan 1993).

Results seem to suggest that an ability to properly define and evaluate sales activities makes it feasible, even desirable, to use behavioral controls. On the other hand, if managers can properly assess salesperson performance, controls that allow salespeople some freedom to learn and implement sales activities themselves (i.e., output controls, social controls, cultural controls) are preferred. However, as sales activities become more routinized, the use of these controls becomes less frequent. Future research should investigate how contemporary task characteristics have impacted SMCS decisions: How has ecommerce influenced SMCS decisions? What about visibility of salesperson interactions through social networks?

Strategic business unit (SBU) size

In general, as the size of sales/marketing units increase, they tend to also become more bureaucratic and formalized (Merchant 1985). Jaworski, Stathakopoulos, and Krishnan (1993) reported SBU size to be associated with a lower use of social controls. Similarly, Kraft (1999) found a negative relationship between the number of salespeople in an SBU and the use of behavioral controls. The implications of these findings suggest that larger organizations require controls that can be easily implemented across sales teams. For example, future research could investigate whether and how larger organizations rely on cultural controls in place of social controls. Further, in organizations that utilize both (social and cultural controls), there is also the question of whether these controls have the potential to conflict.

Sales-force characteristics

Drawing on cognitive evaluation theory, researchers have reported that managers tend to rely on behavioral controls more in situations where the sales force is professionally competent, team oriented, risk averse, intrinsically motivated, recognition motivated, planning oriented, sales-support oriented, and customer oriented (Anderson and Oliver 1987; Cravens et al. 1993). However, the causal direction of these reported effects can be debated. A question therefore arises as to whether the sales force is more professionally competent because a manager places greater emphasis on behavioral controls, or whether the manager chooses behavioral controls because the sales force is professionally competent.

Sales-force observability

In a conceptual article, Stathakopoulos (1996) explored the drivers of behavioral, output, and clan controls from different theoretical perspectives of agency theory, organization theory, and transaction cost analysis. He concluded that in addition to task characteristics and salesperson characteristics, the observability of salesperson behaviors and salesperson outputs should play a major antecedent and moderating role in the selection of SMCSs (Stathakopoulos 1996). An empirical examination, along similar lines, reported finding that sales managers use behavioral controls when outputs are an inadequate measure of salesperson performance, and output controls when sales behaviors are an inadequate measure (Kraft 1999).

These findings are consistent with agency theory; managers tend to choose controls according to the availability of information required to properly specify, monitor, and evaluate results. However, when sales managers have knowledge of the entire transformation process (i.e., the relationship between sales behaviors and sales outputs; Eisenhardt 1985), it has a positive influence on the use of behavioral controls (Kraft 1999). As sales-force behaviors become increasingly less observable due to telecommuting and ecommerce, it will be important for managers to understand how they may utilize informal controls to supplement output controls.

External environment

Studies exploring the drivers of SMCSs from a firm's operating environment and macro environment remain sparse. Only one SMCS study in the review (2% of empirical articles) has evidenced the role of the external environment on SMCS decisions.

Uncertainty

Kraft (1999) found uncertainty (i.e., environmental uncertainty, sales volatility, and diversification of risk) to have a positive relationship with managerial emphasis on behavioral controls. This finding aligns with agency theory because in an uncertain macro environment, salespeople will be less willing to assume risk (Eisenhardt 1985). There are many interesting and unanswered research questions related to how the operating environment influences SMCSs. One final question here, for example, is how do external company stakeholders (e.g., customers, suppliers, regulatory bodies) influence salespeople directly?

Summary

The literature has primarily investigated the influence of task characteristics and sales-force characteristics on SMCS decisions. However, our understanding of how informal controls are developed, communicated, and sustained is still lacking. For example, what role does initiation, training, and socialization of incoming salespeople play in SMCSs? In addition, very little is known about the role played by the external environment in SMCSs. Finally, it is important to note that research to date has not explored mediators that link the internal and external environment to SMCSs or any important contingencies of these relationships. Clearly, more work is needed in this area.

SMCSs as moderators

Some studies (14% of reviewed empirical articles) have shown SMCSs to moderate key sales relationships, with few studies exploring interactions between different types of controls. Here, we synthesize the literature that has investigated the role of SMCSs as moderators of relationships between important sales-related drivers (including other sales controls) and key salesperson- and sales-force/organization–level outcomes. We summarize studies that pertain to the "SMCSs as moderators" box in Figure 1.

Salesperson-level moderators

At the salesperson level of analysis, research has demonstrated only the moderating role of formal behavioral controls (including their disaggregated dimensions) and output controls. These studies account for 10% of SMCS empirical articles investigated.

Formal controls

While job formalization (i.e., prescribed rules) generally has a negative relationship with a salesperson's organizational commitment, output controls have been shown to help mitigate this effect (Agarwal 1999). Higher levels of output controls were also found to reduce the negative effect of job formalization on role ambiguity but not role conflict, while behavioral controls failed to moderate either relationship (Agarwal 1999).

Behavioral controls have been found to help mitigate the negative relationship between salespeople's belief that a great product can "sell itself" (i.e., positive product perceptions) and their effort to sell (Ahearne et al. 2010). However, they also negatively moderate the positive relationship between a salesperson's effort to sell and a customer's product perceptions (Ahearne et al. 2010). These findings emphasize the importance of considering the effect of controls, not only on salespeople, but on the relationships between salespeople and other stakeholders as well. Others have reported finding activity controls to negatively moderate the positive relationship between salespeople's percentage of commission and their intrinsic motivation (Mallin and Pullins 2009).

The positive interaction between output controls and capability controls has been shown to improve salesperson problem solving (e.g., this salesperson tries his or her best to understand and solve our problems; Wang, Dou, and Zhou 2012). By contrast, negative interactions between output and activity controls, as well as activity and capability controls, reduce salesperson problem solving (Wang, Dou, and Zhou 2012). Yet results also indicate that when output controls interact negatively with either activity or capability controls, opportunism decreases (Wang, Dou, and Zhou 2012).

Researchers have also found that capability controls and output controls can be used synergistically to increase indicators of both extrinsic motivation (e.g., recognition seeking) and intrinsic motivation (e.g., task enjoyment) among salespeople (Miao and Evans 2014). Activity controls, on the other hand, have demonstrated the ability to diminish the positive influence that other controls have on salesperson motivation; for example, activity controls mitigated the positive relationship between output controls and task enjoyment (Miao and Evans 2014). We suggest additional research to better understand how all types of controls (including input and informal controls) interact to influence salesperson-level outcomes. In addition, it is essential to explore which outcomes are the most important to consider according to their relationships with salesperson performance.

Sales-force/organization-level moderators

The two studies (4% of reviewed empirical articles) that have offered empirical evidence of SMCSs as moderators of aggregate-level relationships are also the only studies that have examined how formal controls interact with informal controls.

Formal and informal controls

Research suggests that behavioral controls are positively related to sales-force overall performance (e.g., meeting sales growth goals and meeting customer loyalty goals) when preceded by input controls (Kim and Tiwana 2014). On the other hand, output controls have demonstrated a negative relationship with sales-force performance when preceded by input controls (Kim and Tiwana 2014). Yet high use of informal controls weakened both effects (Kim and Tiwana 2014). Further, researchers have reported when output control is low, the positive relationship between self-controls and idea transfer (i.e., sharing of ideas) is strengthened (Flaherty and Pappas 2012). By

contrast, when output control is high, the negative relationship between social controls and idea transfer is reinforced (Flaherty and Pappas 2012). Idea transfer was also shown to have a positive relationship with both salesperson and sales-unit performance (Flaherty and Pappas 2012).

Research on the relationships between formal and informal controls is sparse. Our knowledge of SMCSs indicates that (1) both formal and informal controls are likely to be in use in a sales environment, (2) high control systems have the strongest relationship with key outcomes such as job satisfaction and sales performance, and (3) controls interact in a way that alters key outcomes. This topic represents a major opportunity for additional research exploration.

Summary

Overall, research on how controls influence relationships is rather limited. Some controls appear to interact in a way that harms salesperson motivation. These effects may be the result of either too much control or other information asymmetries. On the contrary, it seems that controls could be used to mitigate the negative relationships that other controls have with favorable outcomes or synergistically enhance the positive relationships. Regardless, results indicate that managers must judiciously select SMCSs. Next, we draw insights from our review of the past literature and identify and propose some key opportunities to guide future exploration in SMCS research.

Future research: key inferences and opportunities for exploration

Our review of the SCMS literature shows that current research primarily provides insights into how the internal environment of a firm influences sales managers' use of behavioral and output controls and how these controls influence salesperson-level consequences. The literature is surprisingly sparse about the determinants, outcomes, and contingencies of other types of controls such as input, self, social, and cultural controls. Web Appendix Table A3 contains statistics on the number of investigated SMCS articles that study each type of control, thus illustrating an imbalance in current knowledge. We present, in Table 2, a summary of key findings from the SMCS literature, along with key research opportunities that remain to be addressed. In this section, we draw some inferences from these findings to propose directions to guide future research on this topic.

Addressing limited and unbalanced understanding of the spectrum of controls

Seventy percent of the studies published on SMCSs have focused narrowly on behavioral and output controls. In addition, the literature has been relatively silent on the study of input and informal controls. This has led to a rather unbalanced development of our understanding of other forms of control.

Need for greater exploration of input controls

Although input controls have a prominent position among the formal controls in seminal SMCS conceptualizations (e.g., Jaworski 1988), our understanding of input controls is severely limited by scant theoretical development and empirical exploration. For example, only one empirical SMCS study has measured input controls and examined their effect on salesperson performance (Kim and Tiwana 2014). Further, in utilizing a scale adapted from the supply chain literature, Kim and Tiwana (2014) operationalized input controls as the extent to which firms recruit salespeople based on their knowledge, skills, and abilities. While an important first step, this scale does not fully capture or reflect the conceptual domain of input controls as proposed by Jaworski (1988) and others (e.g., Flamholtz, Das, and Tsui 1985). Consequently, the literature currently lacks good-quality and psychometrically validated scales for measuring input controls.

Input controls could take multiple unexplored forms such as staffing (e.g., sales support), sales leads, budgets, or resources allocated to a salesperson (Hopwood 1974; Jaworski 1988). While input controls are initiated by management (like behavior-based or outcome-based controls), they occur prior to the start of a sales activity (Jaworski 1988) and therefore are not instrumental to controlling salesperson behavior (during the activity) or their performance outcomes.

As such, input controls represent a potential conundrum for salespeople. On the one hand, such inputs are presented as helpful resources; on the other, input controls may be laden with performance expectations. Such provisions, or lack of, are likely to have a relationship with salesperson motivations, attitudes, satisfaction, and performance, among others. In addition, the allocation of scarce organizational resources has the potential to create intergroup conflict among salespeople and other functional departments within an organization (Hopwood 1974). For example, it would be interesting to investigate how salespeople perceive their own inputs compared to those of their peers.

A rich qualitative exploration into the different forms that input controls take and how they might be used to control salespeople is required toward understanding their potential influence on key sales outcomes. Exploratory research questions of interest include the following: What different forms do input controls take? Are the expectations associated with input controls explicit (i.e., clearly stated by managers), implicit (i.e., alluded to by managers' words or actions), or entirely presumed by salespeople? What

Table 2. SMCS integrated research agenda.

SMCS as antecedents (92% of SMCS empirical articles)		
Salesperson-level outcomes (67% of SMCS empirical articles)	**Summary of key empirical findings**	**Key research opportunity**
Performance *(Cravens et al. 2004; Evans et al. 2007; Jaworski, Stathakopoulos, & Krishnan 1993; Onyemah & Anderson 2009 ; Piercy et al. 2006; Samaraweera & Gelb 2015)*	• Match between formal controls type (e.g., behavioral/process) and performance type (e.g., behavioral/process) is important • High control systems with strong levels of both formal and informal controls have the strongest relationship with salesperson overall performance (i.e., behavioral/ process and output/outcome)	• Can different types of controls compliment and/or be substituted for one another to optimize salesperson performance? If so, under what conditions?
Information asymmetry *(Agarwal 1996; Jaworski & MacInnis 1989; Ramaswami 2002)*	• Information provided by behavioral/ process, output/outcome, and social/peer/ professional controls reduces information asymmetries (between salesperson and sales manager)	• Does the use of multiple different controls types cause information asymmetries due to cognitive overload or goal conflict?
Dysfunctional behaviors *(Choi, Dixon, & Jung 2004; Jaworski & MacInnis 1989; Ramaswami 1996, 2002; Robertson & Anderson 1993)*	• Salespeople who receive activity information are more likely to engage in dysfunctional behaviors, whereas salespeople who receive output/outcome or capability information are less likely to engage in dysfunctional behaviors through supervisor trust • Self-controls reduce salesperson dysfunctional behaviors.	• What effect do different types of controls have at the dimension level (i.e., information, rewards, and punishments)? • Do input and/or cultural controls reduce dysfunctional behaviors?
Motivation *(Oliver & Anderson 1994, 1995)*	• In general, behavioral/process controls are related to intrinsic motivation and output/ outcome controls are related to extrinsic motivation • Different dimensions of formal controls and the strength of controls play a role in salesperson motivation	• What relationships do informal controls have with salesperson motivations (e.g., intrinsic, extrinsic)?
Attitude *(Challagalla & Shervani 1996; Cravens et al. 2004; Jaworski & Kohli 1991; Oliver & Anderson 1994, 1995; Sarin, Challagalla, & Kohli 2012)*	• Overall, behavioral/process controls are positively related to salesperson positive attitude (e.g., job satisfaction); valence of feedback, reinforcement measures, information strength, leadership, and the use of other controls influence these relationships	• What specific combinations of controls have the most positive relationship with job satisfaction under different sales conditions?
Job capabilities *(Oliver & Anderson 1994, 1995; Rouzies & Macquin 2002)*	• Behavioral/process controls have a positive relationship with salesperson job capabilities (e.g., product knowledge, professional competence, attention to agency goals, and sales expertise)	• What relationships do input controls have with different salesperson job capabilities?
Relationships *(Atuahene-Gima & Li 2006)*	• Supervisory use of formal controls influences supervisee trust, but there are many other factors to be considered when determining whether behavioral/process or output/outcome controls are more effective (e.g., internal environment, external environment, relationship length)	• How should controls-use evolve as salespeople develop relationships with their supervisors?

(*Continued on next page*)

Table 2. (*Continued*)

Salesperson-level mediators (10% of SMCS empirical articles)	Summary of key empirical findings	Key research opportunity
Salesperson role perceptions *(Agarwal 1996; Challagalla & Shervani 1996, 1997;Cravens et al. 2004; Jaworski & Kohli 1991; Jaworski, Stathakopoulos, & Krishnan 1993; Lusch & Jaworski 1991; Ramaswami 2002)*	• Information contained in behavioral/process and output/outcome controls provides role clarity; some reinforcements (e.g., activity rewards) do as well. • In general, informal controls reduce salesperson role ambiguity, stress/job tension, and person-role conflict • High control systems with both formal and informal controls reduce salesperson role ambiguity • Both high levels of control over a salesperson's activities, and high accountability without proper guidance lead to salesperson job tension	• How can a balanced SMCS maximize salesperson performance through positive role perceptions?
Salesperson orientations *(Evans et al 2007; Kohli, Shervani, & Challagalla 1998)*	• Output/outcome controls and activity controls have a positive relationship with salesperson's outcome performance through their performance goal orientations • Output/outcome controls and capability controls have a positive relationship with salespersons' learning goal orientations' • Output/outcome controls and capability controls have a positive relationship with salespersons' learning goal orientations'	• How does cultural control interact with a firm's level of customer orientation to influence salesperson job satisfaction and performance?
Salesperson affect (*Cravens et al. 2004; Joshi & Randall 2001; Khan & Saeed 2015; Oliver & Anderson 1994, 1995)*	• Behavioral/process controls and high control systems have a positive relationship with salesperson affect (e.g., organizational commitment) • Affective commitment mediates the positive relationship between SMCS (i.e., behavioral/process, output/outcome, and social/peer/professional controls together) and salesperson overall performance.	• How do behavioral/process controls, self-controls, social/peer/professional controls, and cultural controls differently effect salesperson job satisfaction and performance through organizational commitment?
Sales-manager leadership *(Evans et al. 2007; Panagopoulos & Dimitriadis)*	• The positive relationship between behavioral/process controls and positive salesperson-level outcomes is mediated by sales managers' supportiveness, flexibility, and ability to guide change in a visionary way	• Does sales manager leadership positively mediate the relationship between all different controls types and related positive salesperson-level outcomes?

Salesperson-level contingencies (14% of SMCS empirical articles)	Summary of key empirical findings	Key research opportunity
Task characteristics *(Agarwal 1996; Ramaswami 1996, 2002)*	• Output/outcome controls increase salesperson dysfunctional behaviors when performance documentation is high; behavioral/process controls increase dysfunctional behaviors when procedural knowledge is low • Self-controls reduce dysfunctional behaviors when performance documentation is low and when procedural knowledge is high	• How do task characteristics moderate the relationship between input controls and opportunism?

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Table 2. (*Continued*)

Salesperson goal perceptions *(Fang, Evans, & Zou 2005)*	• Salesperson perceptions about goal difficulty, goal specificity, and goal participation influence the efficacy of formal controls on salesperson performance; national culture plays a role	• How does goal alignment between self, social/peer/professional, and cultural controls influence salesperson performance?
Sales-situation characteristics *(Flaherty, Arnold, & Hunt 2007)*	• Clusters of different types of salespeople (e.g., transactional, relationship-oriented) influence the efficacy of controls on salesperson performance	• How can sales managers be equitable and still flexible when applying SMCS?
Sales-force/organization-level outcomes (24% of SMCS empirical articles)	**Summary of key empirical findings**	**Key research opportunity**
Performance *(Babakus et al. 1996; Baldauf, Cravens, & Piercy 2001a; Cravens et al. 1993; Panagopoulos, Johnson, & Mothersbaugh 2015; Piercy, Cravens, & Morgan 1999; Piercy, Low & Cravens 2004; Samaraweera & Gelb 2015)*	• Behavioral/process controls are positively related to different types of salesforce performance (e.g., behavioral, outcome), which leads to positive financial performance in a sales organization • Informal controls influence salesforce behavioral performance and salesforce customer relationship performance	• Can different types of controls be managed to compliment and substitute for one another in a way that optimizes salesforce performance?
Customer-focused selling *(Guenzi, Baldauf, & Panagopoulos 2014)*	• Behavioral/process controls and social/peer/professional controls are positively related to sales unit effectiveness through adaptive selling • Output/outcome controls and cultural controls are positively related to sale unit effectiveness directly, and indirectly through customer-oriented selling	• What customer contexts are most suitable to different selling philosophies?
Sales-force/organization-level mediators (4% of SMCS empirical articles)	**Summary of key empirical findings**	**Key research opportunity**
Sales-manager OCB *(Piercy, Cravens & Lane 2012)*	• Sales manager OCB fully mediates the positive relationship between behavioral/process controls and sales unit overall performance	• Does sales manager OCB mediate relationships between different types of controls and sales unit overall performance?
Salesperson satisfaction with territory design *(Babakus et al. 1996)*	• The positive relationship between behavioral/process controls and sales organization effectiveness is positively mediated by salesforce satisfaction with territory design	• Which other task characteristics mediate relationships between controls and sales organization effectiveness?
Sales-force/organization-level contingencies (2% of SMCS empirical articles)	**Summary of key empirical findings**	**Key research opportunity**
Supervisor competencies *(Piercy, Cravens, & Lane 2012)*	• Supervisor competencies (i.e., ability to monitor, direct, evaluate, and reward) strengthen the positive relationship between behavioral/process controls and salesforce overall performance	• What sales manager competencies are most relevant to effective SMCS design and implementation?

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Table 2. (*Continued*)

SMCS as consequences (12% of SMCS empirical articles)		
Internal environment (10% of SMCS empirical articles)	**Summary of key empirical findings**	**Key research opportunity**
Task characteristics *(Jaworski & MacInnis 1989; Jaworski, Stathakopoulos, & Krishnan 1993; Ramaswami 2002)*	• Sales manager abilities to define and evaluate sales activities are important determinants of the use of behavioral/ process controls • Sales manager ability to properly assess salesperson performance is an important determinant in the use of output/outcome, social/peer/professional, and cultural controls; as sales activities become more measurable, the use of these controls becomes less significant	• What role does technology play in SMCS decisions?
SBU size *(Jaworski, Stathakopoulos & Krishnan 1993; Kraft 1999)*	• The larger the SBU the lower the use of social/peer/professional controls and behavioral/process controls	• What role do cultural controls play in large SBUs?
Sales-force characteristics *(Cravens et al. 1993)*	• Sales managers tend to use behavioral/ process controls when their salesforce is: professionally competent, team-oriented, risk averse, intrinsically motivated, recognition motivated, planning-oriented, sales support-oriented, and customer-oriented	• How do sales managers adapt SMCS to salesforce characteristics when a salesforce is constantly in flux?
Sales-force observability *(Kraft 1999)*	• Sales managers tend to use behavioral/ process controls when outcomes are unobservable, and output/outcome controls when sales activities are unobservable • When the entire transformation process from sales activities to outcomes is observable, managers favor the use of behavioral/process controls	• What kind of emphasis do leaders of remote sales teams' place on the use of informal controls?
External environment (2% of SMCS empirical articles)	**Summary of key empirical findings**	**Key research opportunity**
Uncertainty *(Kraft 1999)*	• Uncertainty (i.e., environmental uncertainty, sales volatility, and diversification of risk) has a positive relationship with the use of behavioral/ process controls	• Do relationships with external stakeholders serve as controls themselves?
SMCS as moderators (14% of SMCS empirical articles)		
Salesperson-level moderators (10% of SMCS empirical articles)	**Summary of key empirical findings**	**Key research opportunity**
Formal controls *(Agarwal 1999; Ahearne et al. 2010; Mallin and Pullins 2009; Miao & Evans 2014; Wang, Dou, & Zhou 2012)*	• A mismatch between controls and compensation has a negative effect on salesperson intrinsic motivation • SMCS decisions can simultaneously have a positive impact on one relationship and a negative impact on another. • Relationships between formal controls and key salesperson consequences are both enhanced and mitigated by the strong use of another formal controls type	• What are the key salesperson-level factors that should guide decisions about the use of specific controls combinations?

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Table 2. (*Continued*)

Sales-force/organization-level moderators (4% of SMCS empirical articles)	Summary of key empirical findings	Key research opportunity
Formal and informal controls *(Flaherty & Pappas 2012; Kim & Tiwana 2014)*	• Behavioral/process controls (preceded by input controls) positively influence salesforce overall performance and output/outcome controls (preceded by input controls) negatively influence performance; high informal controls weaken both effects • The positive relationship between self-controls and idea transfer is strengthened when output/outcome controls are low, and the negative relationship between social/peer/professional controls and idea transfer is strengthened when output/outcome controls are high	• How do informal controls types (i.e., self, social/peer/professional, and cultural) differentially influence the relationships between formal controls use and salesforce overall performance?

kind of pressure do salespeople experience under input controls? Differences in the ways that managers implement input controls may present some measurement challenges. For example, some managers may take a no-strings approach to the use of input controls, essentially viewing them as a tool for performing the job. Other managers may deliberately use input controls as leverage to control salespeople. Researchers will want to account for salesperson perceptions about the reinforcement of input controls to disaggregate their content from their use.

Need for greater exploration of informal controls

Unlike formal controls, informal controls (i.e., self-, social, and cultural) are worker initiated and therefore are out of managers' direct control (Hopwood 1974; Jaworski 1988; Merchant 1985); such controls may or may not be supportive of managers' objectives and may even conflict with them. A whole body of work examining formal controls suggests that the use of formal controls is not sufficient (e.g., Cravens et al. 2004; Kraft et al. 2012), particularly in an ever-evolving work environment that focuses on worker creativity and autonomy (Pink 2009). Researchers have suggested that in situations where teamwork is dominant, informal controls have the potential to either complement or possibly substitute for formal controls (Jaworski 1988; Kirsch, Ko, and Haney 2010; Ouchi 1979). The fact that informal controls have been underresearched could be attributed to scholars perceiving informal controls as both difficult for sales managers to manage and difficult for researchers to measure (Anderson and Oliver 1987; Darmon 1998; Kirsch, Ko, and Haney 2010; Stathakopoulos 1996).

Even the relatively limited empirical research on informal controls has demonstrated scholars' influence, finding negative relationships with undesirable outcomes such as dysfunctional behaviors, role stress, and information asymmetries (Jaworski and MacInnis 1989; Lusch and Jaworski 1991). At the sales organization level, informal controls have demonstrated a positive relationship with measures of sales-force performance and firm financial performance (Panagopoulos, Johnson, and Mothersbaugh 2015).

The recent Wells Fargo scandal illustrates how an emphasis on formal controls (behavioral "scripts" and output quotas) without adequate development of informal controls could contribute to salespeople committing malpractice and engaging in unethical behavior detrimental to both a company and its clients (Corkery and Cowley 2016; Merle 2016). This situation raises several questions: If cultural controls had been functioning properly, would employees have been comfortable gaming their organization? Would Wells Fargo have been better off promoting an up-selling cultural to be reinforced through informal means? Hence, a more comprehensive and richer understanding of informal controls is warranted. However, before this can be done, a renewed focus on the theoretical development of informal controls is required to provide a framework and develop adequate and psychometrically validated measures of these constructs.

A key difference between formal and informal controls is that formal controls all come from a single source—the principal (i.e., sales manager or supervisor)—who is in a position of authority over the salesperson. This explains why agency theory and transaction cost analysis are both central to the original control

frameworks. Informal controls, on the other hand, come from multiple individual and collective sources (e.g., self, peer group, organization), who typically lack authoritative control. Informal controls are normative controls or shared standards involving what constitutes desirable behaviors, actions, and attitudes (Jaworski 1988). However, salespeople do not necessarily have to "buy into" social norms to feel controlled by them. For example, peers often resort to disapproval or even ostracism as a means of coercing individuals into compliance (Chiaburu and Harrison 2008; Hopwood 1974). Any time that salespeople experience pressure to do something, they experience control, even if that pressure originates from within themselves. In fact, some researchers have argued that if self-controls are fully functioning, they are the most powerful form of controls (e.g., Lawler 1976).

In addition, informal controls are related to a salesperson's identity. The salesperson is a part of the controlling entity (i.e., self, peer group, organization). Therefore, he or she is somehow personally connected to the norms that are being implemented, monitored, and enforced. While extant sales/marketing personnel control frameworks do incorporate organization theory and cognitive evaluation theory, there seems to be a need for a developed theoretical framework for the informal controls more rooted in social identity theory (e.g., Ashforth and Mael 1989). Informal controls are nested, context specific, and not necessarily goal-congruent. As informal controls come from multiple sources and directions, salespeople must manage multiple roles or identities simultaneously. While this issue has received considerable attention in the organizational identity literature (see Pratt and Foreman 2000), it has received only limited attention in the sales literature (see Wieseke et al. 2012). An exploration into the development of informal values, norms, and objectives at the salesperson, sales-team, and sales-organization levels would greatly aid in the theoretical development of a more comprehensive framework of informal controls.

Informal control scales were first introduced by Jaworski and MacInnis (1989). Since then, the few studies investigating informal controls have largely relied on these original scales. However, a closer examination of the seminal works on controls (Dalton 1971; Hopwood 1974, Merchant 1985; Thomas 1983) reveals that only a small set of the descriptors of informal controls were included in the operationalization of Jaworski and MacInnis (1989). For example, self-control involves personal goal setting and goal monitoring; however, the three-item self-controls scale proposed by Jaworski and MacInnis (1989) does not adequately capture the richness and domain of this construct.

We suggest that a combination of deductive and inductive approaches would be an effective way of developing and enhancing current measures of informal controls (e.g., Homburg, Schwemmle, and Kuehnl 2015). Of course, such a research endeavor is subject to some challenges. For example, to properly develop cultural control measures, it will be helpful to interview salespeople from multiple organizations, possibly from multiple countries, to understand different ways (e.g., organizational vocabulary, myths, and rituals) that cultural controls manifest in organizations (Kirsch, Ko, and Haney 2010). Once cultural control scales are developed, survey-based studies could be employed. In addition, similar combinations of qualitative and quantitative approaches could be employed to longitudinally study the transference and establishment of informal controls from a dynamic perspective. In summary, rigorous research will require both time and access. However, researchers may be able to tap into their social networks to overcome access challenges.

Developing a richer understanding at the disaggregated level of dimensions of controls

Challagalla and Shervani (1996) pointed to the fact that all controls necessarily entail both the content of controls (i.e., information) and the use of controls (i.e., rewards and punishments; Anderson and Oliver 1987; Jaworski 1988; Ouchi 1979). For example, by disaggregating activity, capability, and output controls into three dimensions—information, rewards, and punishments—Challagalla and Shervani (1996) discovered that different control dimensions have different relationships with role ambiguity and satisfaction with supervisor. Similarly, Piercy, Cravens, and Morgan (1999) disaggregated the formative behavioral control measure provided by Oliver and Anderson (1994). They found that while directing and evaluating dimensions of behavioral controls have a strong relationship with sales-force performance, dimensions like rewarding do not (see also Panagopoulos and Avlonitis 2008). Additional empirical evidence further confirms that different dimensions (i.e., information, rewards, and punishments) of behavioral and output controls have differential consequences for salespeople (Choi, Dixon, and Jung 2004)—a potential explanation for some of the weak effects and inconsistent results in SMCS research (Baldauf, Cravens, and Piercy 2005).

It is also likely that different dimensions of controls have different antecedents. For example, job characteristics, such as task programmability and salesperson observability, are likely to affect decisions about controls content. However, supervisor and sales force characteristics are more likely to be related to decisions around the use of controls (Darmon and Martin 2011). For example, a sales manager who engages in transactional leadership would be more likely to utilize rewards and punishments than a sales manager who has a laissez-faire leadership style regardless of

controls in use (Dubinsky et al. 1995; MacKenzie, Podsakoff, and Rich 2001). Hence, a more thorough investigation into the dimensions of all control types is required to enhance our understanding of the development of both controls content and controls use, as well as their differential effects on salespeople and sales organizations. In addition, field research at the sales-organization level would aid in developing an understanding of controls content antecedents (e.g., task characteristics, organizational culture) and of antecedents of controls use (e.g., leadership style, sales-force characteristics).

On the other hand, additional research into the effects of information, rewards, and punishments for underexplored rewards types is highly recommended. For example, when managers provide sales support (i.e., input controls), are salespeople more responsive to performance rewards in the form of additional sales support or are they more reactive to performance punishments in the form of sales support being removed? However, before antecedents and consequences of underinvestigated forms of controls can be explored, conceptual development and measurement issues will have to be addressed.

The examination of controls at the dimension level is necessarily complex. This is particularly true considering the ubiquity of controls that operate in a sales environment. As such, there are many challenges related to disaggregating and investigating each type and dimension of controls. For example, it will be imperative to achieve a clean factor analysis between information, rewards, and punishments dimensions of various control types. However, theoretical and empirical evidence both indicate that these distinctions are necessary for a complete and accurate understanding of SMCSs. Hence, researchers should approach these issues incrementally (i.e., one controls dimension at a time) with the mind-set of building on and contributing to a rich body of controls literature.

Exploring control combinations and interactions between controls

Scholars agree that SMCSs are likely to have multiple controls operating simultaneously (Anderson and Oliver 1987; Darmon 1998; Jaworski 1988). Control combinations and interactions are important given that SMCSs with high levels of both formal and informal controls are the most effective (Cravens et al. 2004; Jaworski, Stathakopoulos, and Krishnan 1993). However, to date, empirical SMCS studies have failed to take all controls in use into account (Darmon and Martin 2011). Even when there is some attention paid to both formal and informal controls (e.g., Flaherty and Pappas 2012; Kim and Tiwana 2014), no studies have considered all control types in one comprehensive framework. Consequently, very little is known about how different types of controls interact with, complement, and substitute for one another.

Moorman and Day (2016, 20) noted that "understanding how different incentive and control systems relate to one another, including when they substitute, detract from, or complement one another would be useful". They identify this challenge and opportunity as a research priority related to the achievement of marketing excellence (Moorman and Day 2016). Practically speaking, sales organizations could potentially save time and money dedicated to SMCSs if they had a better understanding of the most effective control combinations under various circumstances.

We suggest implementing additional studies to further explore control combinations and interactions among different types and dimensions of sales controls, especially from a multilevel perspective. A study of this magnitude would, of course, be a grand endeavor. For example, it will be difficult to include all formal and informal control scales (at the dimension level) in a survey instrument. This is not to mention the multitude of necessary antecedents, mediators, moderators, consequences, and other control variables therein. To make matters more complicated, it would be ideal, if not necessary, to survey salespeople from multiple organizations to capture variance. Nevertheless, this may be the only way to answer the call of Moorman and Day (2016) because all forms of control operating in a sales environment should be considered to arrive at a complete understanding of how controls influence one another. Ultimately, SMCS researchers should seek to uncover a full set of viable, control-combination alternatives that managers can choose from according to their unique sales environment.

Exploring the role of external controls

The sales organization does not operate in a vacuum. Aside from key factors and relationships within a firm, there are many other factors in the external environment that have the potential to influence and be influenced by SMCSs. For example, both Anderson and Oliver (1987) and Jaworski (1988) suggested that the external environment would play an important antecedent (and moderating) role in the use of controls. However, only one article (Kraft 1999) has investigated SMCSs as consequences of the external environment.

Panagopoulos et al. (2015) were the first to explicitly suggest that forces external to the firm have the potential to influence salespeople. As a result of their research, they coined the term "external control." Tangentially, research would suggest that salesperson control could be exerted directly by external stakeholders from the macro environment (e.g., regulatory bodies) or the operating environment (e.g., customers, channel partners; Jaworski 1988). For example, in the financial services industry, there is a

movement afoot in the United States that will require financial advisors to act in the fiduciary interest of their customers, by regulation. Whether such a regulatory requirement is codified as a formal control, or promoted as an expected norm by the regulators, it could have a profound influence on the behaviors of financial services salespeople.

As another example, Mullins et al. (2014) found that customer-oriented salespeople tend to underestimate the quality of their customer relationships. This inaccuracy could lead to reduced account profitability. However, when sales managers used behavioral controls, the relationship between a salesperson's customer orientation and his or her perceptions of customer relationship quality was enhanced (Mullins et al. 2014). As a result, the use of such controls led to improved accuracy (Mullins et al. 2014). This line of research suggests that the perceptions of salespeople about their customer relationships has the potential to control their actions and behaviors. Further, the research also suggests that SMCS decisions can be used to effectively manage such perceptions.

Channel partnerships represent another potential source of external control over salespeople. As salespeople develop relationships with individuals who represent firm suppliers and/or consultants, for example, formal controls among firms will influence interactions. In addition, informal controls will develop as individuals establish routines and mutual expectations (Dalton 1971; Hopwood 1974). It is likewise not unusual for normative controls to develop among channel partners according to their past experiences with one another (Weitz and Jap 1995).

As conceptualized, external controls are not only outside of managerial control, they are also largely unobservable to managers because they come from outside the firm (Panagopoulos, Johnson, and Mothersbaugh 2015). However, it is important to note that controls have been defined as "attempts by management or other stakeholders *within the organization* to influence the behavior and activities of marketing personnel to achieve desired outcomes" (Jaworski 1988, 24). This raises an important issue: By referring to forces *outside of the organization* as "controls," does the SMCS literature risk compromising the very definition of controls?[2] We suggest that future research must establish whether external controls fit into this broader construct. If so, the definition of controls will have to be expanded to include factors outside the organization.

Influential factors that are external to the firm are numerous, complex, and unpredictable, which can create perceptions of market turbulence (i.e., loss of internal control, uncertainty, and instability). There is no question that firms that effectively manage market turbulence have and will continue to have a strong competitive advantage over those that do not (e.g., Jones et al. 2005). In other words, although sales managers cannot design the external environment itself, they must understand the nature of the external environment before they will stand a chance at effectively designing SMCSs.

Future investigations of this phenomenon using multiple methodological approaches (e.g., social network analysis) can yield rich insights related to the sales organization (e.g., Ustuner and Iacobucci 2012). It would be interesting to know with what external partners salespeople form ties (i.e., relationships) most often, the strength and valence of those ties, and ultimately the influence that ties have on key sales outcomes. Once researchers develop a more nuanced understanding of the key external factors that influence salesperson behavior and performance, it will be necessary to develop measures designed to capture their nature. For example, are external factors formal or informal? Uncovering the external environment may be time consuming; however, research efforts will pay in dividends. This line of inquiry is invaluable because it is largely unknown by sales managers. In addition, subsequent research could further investigate what types of formal controls (i.e., input, behavioral, output) are most effective among salespeople who experience high levels of external pressure. It would be of interest to investigate how sales managers can design sales jobs in a way that alleviates, circumvents, or even capitalizes on the nature of the external environment.

Conclusions

SMCSs exert significant influence on salespeople and have the potential to lead to desirable organizational outcomes, such as revenue attainment. This exploration of 30 years of SMCS research from prominent sales, marketing, and management journals reveals several important insights as well as opportunities for future exploration. Until now, extant literature has overwhelmingly focused on formal behavioral and output controls. Consequently, the SMCS literature has evolved in an unbalanced way.

There is no question that research focused on input and informal controls, dimensions of controls, and the role of external controls will strengthen theoretical knowledge of the entire spectrum of controls that operate in a sales environment. In addition, conceptual work will provide a foundation for valid and reliable measures for these different types of controls, which will, in turn, allow researchers to empirically examine interactions between all controls in use. Finally, empirical work will enable researchers to determine SMCS combinations that are suited to specific sales contexts. Indeed, only a complete view of SMCSs that accounts for all the pulls and pressures that salespeople experience will provide managers with actionable guidelines on how to design SMCSs in the most efficient and effective manner.

Declaration of interest

No potential conflict of interest was reported by the authors.

Supplemental data

Supplemental data for this article can be accessed on the publisher's website at www.tandfonline.com/rpss

Notes

1. Some authors use the term "process controls" to refer to behavioral controls and "output controls" to refer to outcome controls. We will use these synonyms interchangeably throughout the article.
2. The authors thank one of the anonymous reviewers for raising this point.

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